



Cortex Synapse

— 3-minute pitch

Inspire InterCollege competition · Majuba TVET internal round

10 slides · 459 words · 3:04 at a calm 150 words a minute

0:00

Slide 1 — Cover

Stand still. Look up before you speak.

Good afternoon. My name is Mpendulo Njabulo, and this is Cortex Synapse. Let me start with a number this country celebrated in January.

0:09

Slide 2 — The size of the problem

Let 88% sit for a second. Point at each card as you say it.

Eighty-eight percent. A record matric pass rate. But it counts only the learners who reached the exam desk.

Measure the same class from the day they started Grade One and it is closer to fifty-five percent. Only one in three even wrote mathematics. And the fix that works — a tutor at four hundred and fifty rand an hour — cannot be bought by the learners who need it most.

0:37

Slide 3 — Passing is not understanding

One breath. Then move.

So we are getting better at producing passes. We are not getting better at producing understanding. A thirty percent is a pass — it is not a mark that carries a learner into a degree or a job.

0:52

Slide 4 — Our solution

Slow down. This is your product.

Cortex Synapse is a home-grown AI study companion. A learner drops in a topic, their notes, or a YouTube link, and gets notes aligned to CAPS and NATED, with maths in the notation the exam uses.

It then builds quizzes and flashcards from those notes, so they practise recall instead of re-reading, and the topics they get wrong come back. It is patient at two in the morning, and never makes a learner feel slow.

1:22

Slide 5 — Built, and on the real syllabus

Gesture at the screen. Say it plainly.

This is not a concept. This is the product — every CAPS subject a Grade 10 to 12 learner writes, and the NATED subjects for TVET students.

1:33

Slide 6 — Why us, not them

Fast. Three clauses.

Khan Academy is excellent — and it is American. A private tutor is ours, and costs a family thousands a month. We are South African, affordable, and awake whenever the learner is.

1:46

Slide 7 — Target market

Numbers only. Do not elaborate.

Nine hundred thousand matric candidates a year. Thirteen million learners in basic education. Half a million TVET students with no digital support. We start at Majuba, because that is where I can prove it fastest.

2:00

Slide 8 — Revenue generation

Be firm about the free tier.

The core stays free, permanently. Families who can pay take a low monthly subscription — one tutoring hour, for a whole year. Colleges licence seats per learner, and CSI partners sponsor no-fee schools. Two thousand paying learners covers our costs.

2:16

Slide 9 — Impact on society and the environment

Warmer tone here.

A learner in a school with no laboratory gets the same explanation as one in a private school. Fear drops, because by exam day they have already answered the question fifty times. Nothing is printed. Nothing is driven to.

2:32

Slide 10 — The team, the ask, the close

Look at the judges, not the slide. Pause before the last two lines.

The team is me — building this out of the same classrooms it is built for — and Tony on infrastructure. We are asking for funding for our first year, and access to pilot in schools. One campus, one term, and we bring you the marks.

Because this was never about money. It is about a learner who understands, and is not afraid to write. The better the education, the better the South Africa that comes after us. Thank you.

Cue card

Print this page alone. Seven beats, ten slides, three minutes.

0:00 Hook Slide 1

- Name, Cortex Synapse
- “A number we all celebrated”

0:09 Problem Slides 2–3

- 88% → really 55%
- Only 34% wrote maths
- 83% no lab · tutor R450/hr
- “Passes, not understanding”

0:52 Solution Slides 4–5

- Topic / notes / YouTube in
- CAPS & NATED, real maths notation
- Quizzes + flashcards, weak topics return
- Patient, 2 a.m., never judges

1:33 Why us Slide 6

- Khan = American curriculum
- Tutor = thousands a month
- Us = SA, affordable, always awake

1:46 Market + money Slides 7–8

- 900k matrices · 13m learners · 500k TVET
- Start: Majuba + Newcastle schools
- Free forever · family plan · seats · CSI
- Break-even 2 000 learners

2:16 Impact + team Slides 9–10

- Same explanation, any school
- Practice beats panic
- No paper, no travel, low data
- Me + Tony · already built

2:32 Ask + close Slide 10

- Funding · school pilot access
- “One campus, one term, we bring the marks”
- “Understands, and is not afraid to write”

Timing check

Read it aloud once with a stopwatch. At a calm 150 words a minute this runs 3:04. Most people speed up under pressure, so expect nearer 2:50 on the day.

If you run long, cut in this order:

- Slide 4, second paragraph — the quizzes-and-flashcards sentence.
- Slide 2 — the tutor-cost sentence (the number is on the slide anyway).
- Slide 7 — drop the thirteen-million line, keep 900k and 500k.

Never cut the last two lines. They are the reason you are in the room.

Before you present

- Once the app is deployed, add your live learner number to slide 5 — one line under the timeline, e.g. “First cohort: 40 learners, Majuba TVET”. A real number beats a projection with judges.
- Confirm the founder name on slides 1 and 10 reads exactly as you want it.
- Open the deck in Presenter View — every slide carries these words as speaker notes.
- Have the app open in a browser tab in case a judge asks to see it live.